

to strengthen their hands in the work of the house of God, the God of Israel.

CHAPTER VII.

1 ¶ And after these things, in the reign of Artaxerxes the king of Persia, 'Ezra^a the son of Serayah, the son of 'Azaryah, the son of Chilkiah,

2 The son of Shallum, the son of Zadok, the son of Achiub,

3 The son of Amaryah, the son of 'Azaryah, the son of Merayoth,

4 The son of Zerachyah, the son of 'Uzzi, the son of Bukki,

5 'The son of Abishua', the son of Phinehas, the son of Elazar, the son of Aaron the chief priest:

6 This 'Ezra went up from Babylon; and he was a practised expounder^b in the law of Moses, which the LORD the God of Israel hath given; and the king gave him, according to the hand of the LORD his God upon him, all his request.

7 And there went up some of the children of Israel, and of the priests, and the Levites, and the singers, and the gate-keepers, and the temple-servants, unto Jerusalem, in the seventh year of king Artaxerxes.

8 And he came to Jerusalem in the fifth month, which was in the seventh year of the king.

9 For on the first day of the first month was the commencement of the expedition from Babylon, and on the first day of the fifth month came he to Jerusalem, according to the good hand of his God upon him.

10 For 'Ezra had directed his heart to inquire in the law of the LORD, and to do it, and to teach in Israel statutes and ordinances.

11 ¶ Now this is the copy of the letter which king Artaxerxes gave unto 'Ezra the priest, the expounder of the law, the expounder of the words of the commandments of the LORD, and of his statutes for Israel.

12 Artaxerxes, the king of kings, unto

'Ezra the priest, the expounder of the law of the God of heaven, the perfect, and so forth.

13 By me is the order given, that every one who is freely willing in my kingdom out of the people of Israel, and their priests and Levites, to go up to Jerusalem, may go up with thee;

14 Forasmuch as thou art sent on the part of the king, and of his seven counsellors, to make inquiry concerning Judah and Jerusalem, according to the law of thy God which is in thy hand;

15 And to carry the silver and gold, which the king and his counsellors have freely offered unto the God of Israel, whose habitation is in Jerusalem,

16 And all (freewill offerings of) silver and gold that thou canst find in all the province of Babylon, with the freewill offerings which the people and the priests offer willingly for the house of their God which is in Jerusalem.

17 Therefore mayest thou buy speedily with this money bullocks, rams, lambs, with their meat-offerings and their drink-offerings, and offer them upon the altar of the house of your God which is in Jerusalem.

18 And whatsoever shall seem good to thee, and to thy brethren, to do with the rest of the silver and the gold, that do according to the will of your God.

19 And the vessels which have been given unto thee for the service of the house of thy God, deliver thou before the God of Jerusalem.

20 And the remainder that will yet be needful for the house of thy God, which thou shalt have occasion to procure,^c procure out of the king's treasure-house.

21 And by me, me king Artaxerxes, is the order given unto all the treasurers who are beyond the river, that whatsoever 'Ezra the priest, the expounder of the law of the God of heaven, may demand of you, shall be done speedily,

22 Up to one hundred talents of silver,

^a According to Zunz's chronological tables, there elapsed 58 years between the finishing of the temple under Zerubabel and Zechariah and their associates to the immigration of 'Ezra under *Arthachshasth*, as he is called here. But Rashi makes him identical with Darius—*Arthachshasth* being taken as a general appellation of the Persian kings; and others deem 'Ezra identical with Malachi.

^b Rashi. Lit. "scribe," but the word סופר *sopher*, though often meaning secretary or scribe, signifies also one learned in religion; the word frequently occurring in the Mishnah סופרים "the learned," or "scholars;" but it is also possible that 'Ezra was a state secretary to the Persian king, wherefore he was sent to Judah.

^c Lit. "to give," "to pay out."